

Technology Security in Christian Organizations

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Goals:

1. Identify and Assess Vulnerabilities in Organizational Technology Systems

Evaluate an organization's current software, hardware, and policies to identify areas that are susceptible to security breaches or operational failures.

2. Develop and Implement Disaster Preparedness Plans

Create comprehensive disaster recovery and preparedness plans, ensuring that critical data and services can be restored quickly in the event of a system failure, cyberattack, or natural disaster.

3. Promote Security Awareness and Best Practices

Explain the importance of educating staff and volunteers about security best practices, such as password management, phishing awareness, and the use of multi-factor authentication. Explain how the church adheres to ethical codes of conduct through a data usage awareness campaign.

Our Mission

Note from the Pastor

Pastor John Matthews
Grace Community Fellowship
Springfield, USA

To: Security Consulting Service
Subject: Technology Security Concerns for Grace Community Fellowship

Thank you for the thorough review of our technology practices at Grace Community Fellowship. As you know, our church's mission is to love God, serve people, and make disciples. In today's digital world, technology is integral to how we carry out this mission—whether it's connecting with our congregation, managing donations, or ensuring our ministries run smoothly. However, this reliance on technology also brings risks that we need to address, and there are several key areas that are particularly important to me and the leadership team.

First and foremost, **maintaining the trust of our congregation** is critical. Our members entrust us with their personal information, and we must do everything we can to protect that trust. Any breach of our communication systems or data security could severely damage the relationship we've worked so hard to build with our congregation.

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Equally important is **financial stability**. We rely heavily on digital donations to support our ministry, and it's essential that these systems are secure and reliable. Financial fraud or even minor mishandling could result in significant losses and undermine the confidence our members have in us to manage their generous contributions.

Another area of concern is **the consistency and reliability of our worship services and events**. Our services, especially on major holidays like Christmas and Easter, are vital to our ministry, and any disruptions—whether technical failures or issues with volunteer coordination—could negatively impact the experience for both our members and guests. Ensuring smooth operations during these high-traffic events is essential to our mission.

We also recognize the need for **operational efficiency**. Many of the technological tools we've adopted have helped streamline our processes, but we've learned that some of them may be more complex than necessary, leading to inefficiencies and occasional errors. Simplifying these systems where possible will allow us to focus more on ministry and less on administration.

As our church grows, we need to pay attention to **legal and regulatory compliance**: As we handle sensitive data, ensuring compliance with applicable data privacy laws, such as GDPR or CCPA, is a priority. This not only protects us legally but also reinforces our commitment to ethical stewardship of our members' personal information.

Reliability and Scalability: As our church grows, our technology needs to grow with us. We want to ensure that the systems we invest in today will continue to serve us effectively in the future without requiring frequent, costly overhauls.

Protecting Our Mission and Vision: Any significant disruption—whether due to a security breach or operational failure—could interfere with our ability to carry out our mission. Protecting our technological systems is key to ensuring we can continue serving God and our congregation without interruption.

Crisis Communication Preparedness: If we were to face a major issue—such as a data breach or a service outage—we want to be prepared to communicate clearly and transparently with our congregation. This is vital to maintaining trust and ensuring that people receive timely information during critical moments.

We greatly value your expertise and look forward to working with you to address these areas and strengthen our church's technology infrastructure. With your guidance, we hope to not only mitigate potential risks but also ensure that our technology continues to support and enhance our ministry for years to come.

Thank you again for your commitment to helping us safeguard our church and its mission.

In Christ,

Pastor John Matthews

In this email from Pastor John Matthews, I found key focuses and will list their priority based on my understanding.

1. Maintaining the trust of our congregation - This is an overarching goal that encapsulates the goals below and is paramount to the ministry.
2. Financial stability - Financial fraud would be a major concern here. Review status reports and consumer reviews for software before committing.
3. The consistency and reliability of our worship services and events along with scalability. - the goal is to be able to grow and reliably serve the congregation.
4. operational efficiency - The ability to simplify current processes to reduce administration strain.
5. legal and regulatory compliance - Focus on data privacy, GDPR or CCPA laws to protect the ministry from legal complications.

Technology Security Audit Tables

The tables below use the Part 4 audit checklist categories for each technology in use at Grace Community Fellowship. Status legend: Good = strong practice confirmed, Adequate = acceptable but needs improvement, Urgent = gap or prior incident to address, TBD = evidence required.

Breeze ChMS

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Core member/event system; verify current data map and vendor backup cadence.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Good	Cloud-hosted with encrypted connections and payment industry-aligned controls; database backups every 6 hours, code/media daily; confirm hosting region (see 19).
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Enforce role-based access, multi-factor authentication for admins, prompt removal of departed staff/volunteers; unique subdomain login.
Donation and Financial Security	Adequate	Supports online giving; if enabled, validate payment security documentation and restrict exports/application programming interface keys (see 19).
Communication Tools Security	N/A	Not a primary comms platform.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not used for content delivery.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Track vendor release notes, rotate application programming interface tokens, and review Tithe.ly integrations if enabled.

Recommendation: Support with conditions (Moderate Risk) retain Breeze; enforce multi-factor authentication and role hygiene, confirm backup/region posture, align payment security evidence if using giving, and audit application programming interface tokens.

Pushpay

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Primary giving channel; validate configuration aligns with finance policies.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Adequate	Published privacy/security policy (Jul 9, 2025); confirm encrypted connections, uptime service levels, and data residency (see 21).
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Require multi-factor authentication for finance admins and prohibit shared logins.
Donation and Financial Security	Adequate	Confirm payment security attestations, fraud monitoring, and encryption at rest/in transit (see 1–3, 21).
Vendor Security Reviews	Urgent	Recent user reviews (Trustpilot Sep 2025, Jun 2024; TrustRadius 2024) and Better Business Bureau complaints (billing issues, stored cards, cancellation lock-in across 2023-2025) highlight usability, contract, and billing risk; re-evaluate vendor fit and ensure exit/contingency plan.
Communication Tools Security	N/A	Not a comms platform.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Schedule periodic reviews of integrations and webhooks after vendor updates.

Recommendation: Replace (High Risk) begin exit planning toward Tithe.ly or Planning Center Giving based on recurring billing/refund complaints; enforce multi-factor authentication and a refund/escalation playbook until migration completes.

ProPresenter

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Audio-visual workstation software; keep device inventory tied to services.
Cloud and Hosting Security	N/A	Primarily on-prem software; limit network exposure.
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Uses Account Manager roles (owner/admin/member) plus network passwords for remote connections and application programming interface; ensure unique logins, seat control, and operating system permissions (see 6–8).
Donation and Financial Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Communication Tools Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	Adequate	Control content sources, sanitize media, and keep offline fallback slides.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Apply patches during maintenance windows; note user reports of Windows build glitches and video stutter; test updates before Sunday.
Vendor Security Reviews	Adequate	Mixed reliability feedback (Reddit thread, GetApp); better stability on macOS, Windows users cite bugs/performance; monitor vendor fixes.

Recommendation: Support with conditions keep ProPresenter; prioritize macOS where possible, stage/rollback Windows updates around services, pretest video playback, and enforce Account Manager roles plus network passwords for remote connections and application programming interface access.

BoxCast

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Critical for livestreams; document ingest points and endpoints.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Adequate	Confirm streams use encrypted delivery and restrict embed domains.
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Lock down stream keys, admin roles, and multi-factor authentication for console access.
Donation and Financial Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Communication Tools Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	Adequate	Monitor for hijacking attempts; audit who can start/stop broadcasts.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Track firmware/app updates on encoders/devices; note recent minor outages (Oct 20: 2h35m; Nov 2: 5m; Dec 5: 20m) (see status history).
Vendor Security Reviews	Adequate	Status history shows limited outages; request uptime targets/history and maintain failover.

Recommendation: Support with evidence retain BoxCast only after confirming uptime targets/history; document stream-key handling and keep YouTube Live as a failover.

Eventbrite

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Event RSVPs/ticketing; address usability gaps for older members.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Adequate	Review data retention and privacy settings; Eventbrite publishes a privacy policy (Jan 27, 2025) and provides organizer/consumer controls (see policy).
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Use individual accounts with multi-factor authentication; avoid shared organizer logins.
Donation and Financial Security	Adequate	If collecting paid registrations, confirm payment processor compliance and refund controls.
Vendor Security Reviews	Urgent	Recent complaints (Trustpilot Nov–Dec 2025; Better Business Bureau 456 complaints/172 last 12 months) cite non-refunded cancellations, locked payouts, and forced auto-renew/missed refunds require clear refund service levels and organizer screening.
Communication Tools Security	Adequate	Vet outbound messaging templates and unsubscribe handling.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Periodically review integrations (calendar, email) after vendor changes.

Recommendation: Replace (High Risk) shift registrations to Planning Center Registrations or SignUpGenius given refund/payout complaints; if retained, mandate escrowed payouts and written refund service levels.

Planning Center Services

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Good	Volunteer scheduling backbone; ensure roster accuracy post-2023 upgrade.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Good	Cloud-hosted with published privacy/security notice (Nov 14, 2025); confirm data segregation for ministries (see 9–12).
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Enforce least privilege for schedulers vs volunteers; require multi-factor authentication for admins.
Donation and Financial Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Communication Tools Security	Adequate	Review reminder/notification settings to avoid oversharing contact data.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Monitor vendor updates that impact mobile apps and calendar sync.
Vendor Security Reviews	Good	Positive user feedback on reliability/scheduling (Reddit, SoftwareAdvice 4.7/5, G2 2025) and Better Business Bureau shows zero complaints; occasional Sunday load issues noted; confirm uptime service levels and support paths (see 9–12).

Recommendation: Support continue Planning Center Services as the volunteer backbone; validate uptime service levels, add Sunday performance monitoring, and keep multi-factor authentication/least-privilege enforced.

Subsplash

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Hosts website/app; central hub for sermons and giving links.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Good	Certificate renewal was automated after 2022 outage; verify content delivery network and web application firewall protections to keep posture strong.
Authentication and Access Control	Good	Limit content management system editors, enable multi-factor authentication if available, and audit application programming interface keys.
Donation and Financial Security	N/A	Payments routed elsewhere; ensure only vetted giving links are embedded.
Communication Tools Security	Adequate	Review push notification permissions and privacy disclosures.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	Adequate	Validate embedded streams and file permissions before publishing.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Track platform updates that affect mobile app builds and plugins.
Vendor Security Reviews	Adequate	Mixed feedback: positive all-in-one reviews vs Trustpilot complaints about upselling, delays, cancellations; Better Business Bureau shows 4 complaints in 3 years; require clear service levels, refund terms, and support response targets (see 13–16).

Recommendation: Support with conditions retain Subsplash; verify web application firewall and content delivery network protections, require clear contract/support/refund terms given mixed reviews, and audit editor/API access quarterly.

Aplos

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Finance backbone; aligns with accounting processes adopted in 2019.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Adequate	Published privacy/security notice (Sep 24, 2025); US-hosted; confirm data residency details and security measures for financial data (see 19).
Authentication and Access Control	Adequate	Enforce multi-factor authentication, unique logins, and segregation of duties for approvals.
Donation and Financial Security	Adequate	Verify payment security and independent attestation reports, audit trails, and encryption coverage.
Communication Tools Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Schedule reviews after major releases; validate export integrations.

Recommendation: Support retain Aplos contingent on current payment security evidence, enforced multi-factor authentication and segregation of duties, and periodic audit of exports/integrations.

Flocknote

Audit Category	Status	Notes
General Technology Review	Adequate	Primary email/text platform; prior breach exposed member emails.
Cloud and Hosting Security	Adequate	Published privacy/security policy (Feb 14, 2023); request current data retention details.
Authentication and Access Control	Urgent	Past shared logins led to 2021 breach; verify multi-factor authentication and strong password policy now enforced for all admins.
Donation and Financial Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Communication Tools Security	Adequate	Ensure opt-outs honored, phishing awareness for senders, and incident response plan tested.
Live Streaming and Presentation Security	N/A	Not applicable.
Software Maintenance and Updates	Adequate	Monitor vendor updates that affect contact lists or API access.
Vendor Security Reviews	Adequate	Strong user satisfaction (Trustpilot 4.7/5, Capterra 4.7/5) but past breach and shared logins raise risk; keep multi-factor authentication and admin hygiene enforced (see 17–18).

Recommendation: Support with remediation (Elevated Risk) continue Flocknote only after multi-factor authentication and unique admins are enforced and roles reviewed; otherwise migrate to a secured alternative (i.e., Mailchimp or Church Community Builder).

Report summary

The tables above are how I graded the ministry's current technologies. Several platforms are sound with routine controls; a few need targeted remediation; two should be replaced because of sustained vendor and billing risks. A simplification path can also reduce vendor sprawl.

Key vulnerabilities: Pushpay and Eventbrite have sustained billing/refund and contract complaints; Flocknote had a prior breach tied to shared logins; ProPresenter can be unstable on Windows builds if updates are not staged; BoxCast has had brief outages; Breeze, Flocknote, and ProPresenter all depend on enforcing strong authentication and role hygiene to avoid repeat incidents (see sources 1–21).

Planning Center Services and Subsplash hosting and access controls look solid. BoxCast is operationally adequate given limited, short outages; keep it only after confirming uptime targets/history and with a livestream failover. Aplos remains fine when strong authentication and role separation are enforced. These can be reached with ongoing access reviews, backup/restore validation, and API key rotation.

Breeze is serviceable with clear cloud/backup posture; confirm region/backup details and keep strong authentication and role hygiene. ProPresenter is stable if updates are staged and macOS prioritized; Windows builds require pretesting. Flocknote stays viable only after strong authentication and unique admin accounts are enforced; otherwise move to a secured communications tool. Pushpay and Eventbrite show sustained billing/refund and contract complaints; replace them (i.e., Planning Center Giving; Planning Center Registrations) while keeping strong authentication and a refund/escalation playbook until cutover completes. Align service levels, privacy commitments, and refund terms for any temporary Eventbrite use.

Consolidate people, volunteers, registrations, and giving into Planning Center; drop Breeze, Pushpay, and Eventbrite to remove overlap. Pick one communications tool (Flocknote with enforced strong authentication and unique admins, or a simple email/SMS tool) to avoid duplication. Keep ProPresenter for slides. Choose BoxCast with a YouTube Live failover, or go YouTube only if simpler streaming is acceptable. Keep Subsplash only if the app/media hub is essential; otherwise a simple website plus Planning Center links and YouTube embeds may suffice. This reduces logins, duplicate payment processors, and redundant event tools.

References

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10. SoftwareAdvice: Planning Center reviews (overall 4.7/5; ease-of-use 4.4, support 4.6) - <https://www.softwareadvice.com/accounting/planning-center-profile/reviews/>
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14. SoftwareAdvice: Subsplash reviews and ratings - <https://www.softwareadvice.com/nonprofit/subsplash-profile/reviews/>
15. Trustpilot: Subsplash user reviews (2025 mix of positive and critical) - <https://www.trustpilot.com/review/subsplash.com>
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